10 MORE LINES, AND WHAT TO SAY WHEN YOU'RE LOST

What to Say to Your Engineers in Your First Month

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1 When you check in, ask what's in the way

Ask about the thing slowing them down, not how they feel about the week.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "Anything I can help with?"
> Instead say: "What's one thing I could take off your plate this week?"
>
> Don't say: "Just checking in on this."
> Instead say: "Is anything waiting on me or another team?"

Write down what they say, and come back with it handled.

2 When you need a date, ask what it costs

Ask what has to give before you ask for a yes.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "Is end of month still realistic?"
> Instead say: "What's the riskiest part between now and end of month?"
>
> Don't say: "Can we squeeze this in?"
> Instead say: "What drops if we add this?"

Whatever drops, you tell the people who care. Don't leave that news to the engineer.

3 When you want to stay out of the way, read first

Staying close to the work beats staying away from it. Read it, then ask about it.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Don't say: "Ping me if you need anything."
> Instead say: "I read the design doc. Can I ask about the retry part?"
>
> Don't say: "I'll stay out of the technical stuff."
> Instead say: "Walk me through it once, and I'll read the rest myself."

Read the doc before the meeting, not during it.

4 When you're sizing work, ask what it touches

Ask what the change reaches and what nobody knows yet.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Is this a big lift?"
> Instead say: "What else breaks if we change this?"
> Don't say: "Ballpark, how long?"
> Instead say: "What would you need to find out before you could size it?"

Anything on that list owned by another team is someone you need to tell.

5 When you need them, say what and when

Skip the apology. Say what you need and by when.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Sorry to bug you again."
> Instead say: "One question on the export bug. Got a minute?"
> Don't say: "Whenever you get a chance."
> Instead say: "Can you look at this before 3? It's blocking the release notes."

If it can wait, save it up and send one message instead of five.

6 When you don't follow what they said, say it back

Put the answer in your own words and let them fix it.

> EXAMPLE
> Don't say: "Okay, makes sense." (when it doesn't)
> Instead say: "Let me say it back. We can't ship until the other team updates their API, right?"

Getting it wrong out loud is fine. Nodding along is what they notice.

Check before your next 1:1 with an engineer

Run this before you walk in:

- [ ] Will you ask what's in the way, not how it's going?
- [ ] If you need a date, do you know what it would cost?
- [ ] Did you read the doc or PR before you showed up?
- [ ] Do you know what this change touches?
- [ ] Did you say what you need and by when?